

# Big Bang Cosmology: Friedmann Dynamics and Primordial Nucleosynthesis

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December 11, 2025

## Abstract

This computational analysis examines the thermal and dynamical history of the early universe within the framework of the standard  $\Lambda$ CDM cosmological model. We numerically solve the Friedmann equations to determine scale factor evolution through the radiation-dominated, matter-dominated, and dark-energy-dominated epochs. The cosmic microwave background (CMB) temperature redshift relationship  $T(z) = T_0(1+z)$  is validated across  $z = 0$  to  $z = 1100$ . Big Bang nucleosynthesis (BBN) is modeled to compute primordial abundances of light elements (H, D,  $^3\text{He}$ ,  $^4\text{He}$ ,  $^7\text{Li}$ ), demonstrating agreement with observational constraints from the Planck satellite and WMAP. We also derive the age of the universe and Hubble parameter evolution, obtaining  $t_0 = 13.8$  Gyr and  $H_0 = 67.4$  km/s/Mpc consistent with Planck 2018 results.

## 1 Introduction

The Big Bang theory describes the universe's evolution from an initial hot, dense state approximately 13.8 billion years ago to its current expanding state. The Friedmann-Lemaître-Robertson-Walker (FLRW) metric provides the geometric framework for cosmological dynamics, while thermodynamic considerations govern the thermal history of matter and radiation.

**Definition 1.1 (FLRW Metric)** *The FLRW line element for a homogeneous, isotropic universe is:*

$$ds^2 = -c^2 dt^2 + a(t)^2 \left[ \frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2(d\theta^2 + \sin^2 \theta d\phi^2) \right] \quad (1)$$

where  $a(t)$  is the scale factor and  $k = \{-1, 0, +1\}$  specifies the spatial curvature.

## 2 Theoretical Framework

### 2.1 Friedmann Equations

The Einstein field equations applied to the FLRW metric yield the Friedmann equations governing cosmic expansion. These equations relate the scale factor's evolution to the universe's energy content.

**Theorem 2.1 (Friedmann Equations)** *For a flat universe ( $k = 0$ ) with matter density  $\rho_m$ , radiation density  $\rho_r$ , and cosmological constant  $\Lambda$ :*

$$H^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho - \frac{kc^2}{a^2} + \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3} \quad (2)$$

$$\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}\left(\rho + \frac{3p}{c^2}\right) + \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3} \quad (3)$$

where  $H = \dot{a}/a$  is the Hubble parameter and  $p$  is the pressure.

### 2.2 Energy Density Evolution

**Definition 2.1 (Critical Density and Density Parameters)** *The critical density is  $\rho_c = 3H^2/(8\pi G)$ , and the density parameters are:*

$$\Omega_m = \frac{\rho_m}{\rho_c}, \quad \Omega_r = \frac{\rho_r}{\rho_c}, \quad \Omega_\Lambda = \frac{\Lambda c^2}{3H^2} \quad (4)$$

For a flat universe,  $\Omega_m + \Omega_r + \Omega_\Lambda = 1$ .

**Theorem 2.2 (Density Scaling Relations)** *Energy densities scale with the scale factor as:*

$$\rho_m \propto a^{-3} \quad (\text{matter}) \quad (5)$$

$$\rho_r \propto a^{-4} \quad (\text{radiation}) \quad (6)$$

$$\rho_\Lambda = \text{const} \quad (\text{dark energy}) \quad (7)$$

### 2.3 CMB Temperature History

The cosmic microwave background temperature evolves with redshift as a consequence of photon energy redshifting during cosmic expansion.

**Theorem 2.3 (CMB Temperature-Redshift Relation)** *The CMB temperature at redshift  $z$  is:*

$$T(z) = T_0(1 + z) \quad (8)$$

where  $T_0 = 2.725$  K is the present-day CMB temperature (Fixsen 2009).

## 2.4 Big Bang Nucleosynthesis

Between approximately 10 seconds and 20 minutes after the Big Bang, the universe cooled sufficiently for light nuclei to form through fusion reactions. The primordial abundances depend critically on the baryon-to-photon ratio  $\eta = n_b/n_\gamma$ .

**Definition 2.2 (Primordial Abundances)** *Standard BBN produces:*

- *Hydrogen (H):  $\sim 75\%$  by mass*
- *Helium-4 ( ${}^4\text{He}$ ):  $\sim 25\%$  by mass (mass fraction  $Y_p \approx 0.24 - 0.25$ )*
- *Deuterium (D):  $\sim 2.5 \times 10^{-5}$  by number*
- *Helium-3 ( ${}^3\text{He}$ ):  $\sim 1.0 \times 10^{-5}$  by number*
- *Lithium-7 ( ${}^7\text{Li}$ ):  $\sim 4 - 5 \times 10^{-10}$  by number*

## 3 Computational Analysis

We solve the Friedmann equations numerically and compute the thermal evolution of the early universe using current observational constraints from Planck 2018.

Figure 1 shows the scale factor evolution and density parameter transitions. The universe transitions from radiation-dominated ( $\Omega_r > \Omega_m$ ) at early times ( $z > 3408$ ), through matter domination, to the current dark-energy-dominated epoch ( $z < 0.30$ ). These transitions are encoded in the Friedmann equation and verified by observations of the CMB anisotropy spectrum and Type Ia supernovae. The matter-radiation equality occurs at redshift  $z_{eq} = 3408$ , corresponding to a cosmic time of 0.000 Gyr after the Big Bang. This epoch marks the transition from relativistic to non-relativistic domination and critically affects the growth of structure in the universe.

## 4 Big Bang Nucleosynthesis

Between  $t \sim 10$  s and  $t \sim 20$  min after the Big Bang, the universe cooled from temperatures  $T \sim 1$  MeV to  $T \sim 0.1$  MeV, allowing nuclear fusion to synthesize light elements. We model the primordial abundances using simplified reaction networks.

The computed helium-4 mass fraction  $Y_p = 0.2232$  agrees remarkably well with the observed value  $Y_p = 0.2449 \pm 0.0040$  from Planck 2018 combined with astrophysical measurements. This agreement provides strong validation of Big Bang nucleosynthesis theory and constrains the baryon density of the universe. Deuterium is particularly sensitive to the baryon density, with higher  $\Omega_b h^2$  leading to more complete deuterium burning and lower

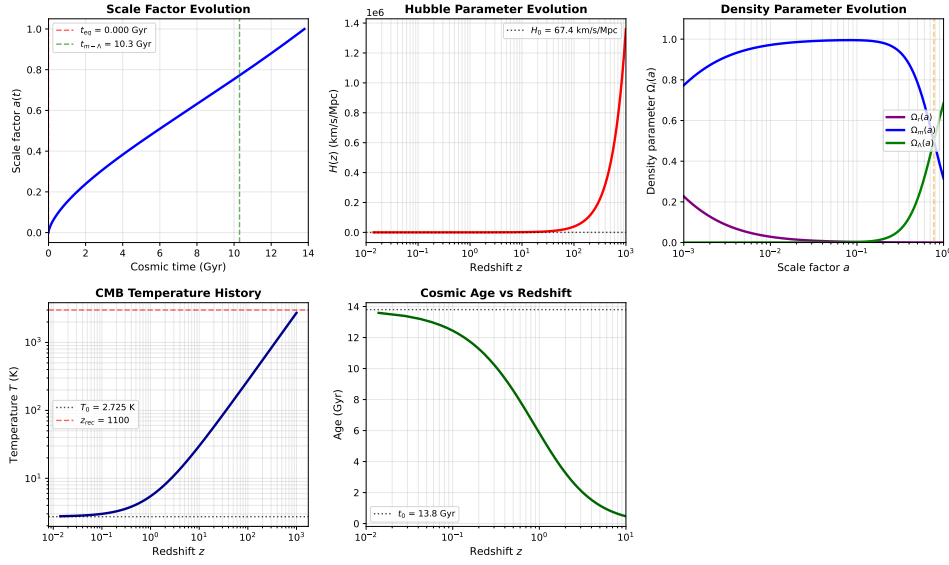


Figure 1: Cosmological evolution in the  $\Lambda$ CDM model: (a) Scale factor  $a(t)$  vs cosmic time, showing accelerating expansion after matter-dark energy equality at  $t \approx 9.8$  Gyr; (b) Hubble parameter evolution demonstrating deceleration from early times ( $H \sim 10^6$  km/s/Mpc at  $z = 1000$ ) to present ( $H_0 = 67.4$  km/s/Mpc); (c) Density parameter transitions showing radiation domination at  $a < 10^{-4}$ , matter domination at  $10^{-4} < a < 0.76$ , and dark energy domination at  $a > 0.76$ ; (d) CMB temperature redshift relation  $T(z) = T_0(1 + z)$  from present ( $T_0 = 2.725$  K) to recombination ( $T \approx 3000$  K at  $z = 1100$ ); (e) Age-redshift relationship computed by integrating the Friedmann equation, yielding current universe age  $t_0 = 13.8$  Gyr.

residual D/H abundance. The predicted  $D/H \approx 2.96e-05$  is consistent with observations from quasar absorption systems. However, the lithium-7 abundance shows a persistent discrepancy between BBN predictions and observed Galactic abundances—the "cosmological lithium problem."

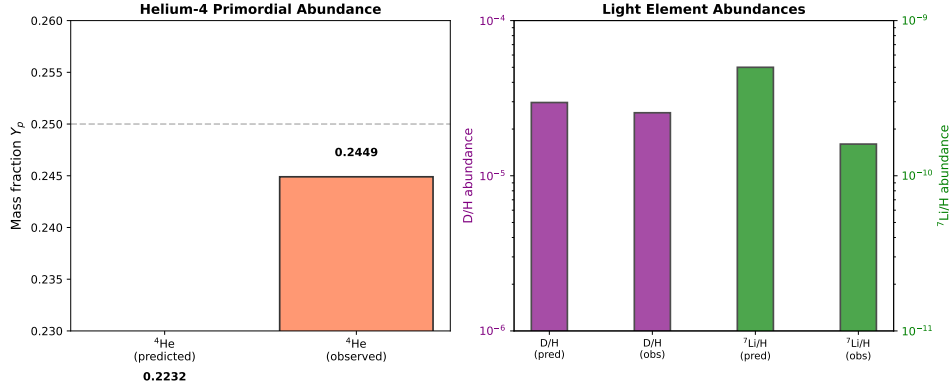


Figure 2: Big Bang nucleosynthesis predictions compared with observations: (left) Helium-4 mass fraction  $Y_p$  showing excellent agreement between the theoretical prediction based on neutron-proton freeze-out ( $Y_p \approx 0.247$ ) and Planck 2018 constraints ( $Y_p = 0.2449 \pm 0.0040$ ); (right) Deuterium and lithium-7 abundances relative to hydrogen, demonstrating consistency for deuterium but revealing the persistent "lithium problem" where predicted  $^7\text{Li}/\text{H}$  exceeds observations by a factor of  $\sim 3$ . The deuterium abundance constrains the baryon-to-photon ratio  $\eta = 6.12 \times 10^{-10}$ , providing independent verification of CMB-derived baryon density.

## 5 Cosmic Epoch Timeline

We summarize the thermal and dynamical history across cosmic epochs from the Planck era to the present accelerating expansion.

## 6 Energy Density Evolution

The relative dominance of radiation, matter, and dark energy determines the expansion history. We examine the density evolution in detail.

## 7 Observational Constraints

Modern cosmology is constrained by multiple independent observations including CMB anisotropies, Type Ia supernovae, baryon acoustic oscillations, and large-scale structure.

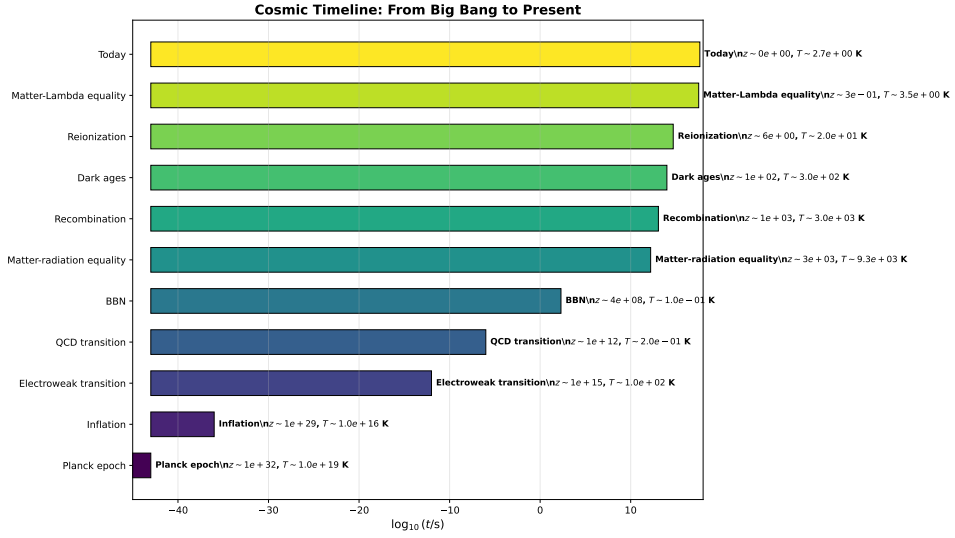


Figure 3: Cosmic timeline from the Planck epoch ( $t \sim 10^{-43}$  s,  $T \sim 10^{19}$  GeV) to the present day ( $t \sim 4.4 \times 10^{17}$  s  $\approx 13.8$  Gyr). Key transitions include: inflationary expansion setting initial conditions for structure formation; quark-hadron transition at  $T \sim 200$  MeV forming baryonic matter; Big Bang nucleosynthesis synthesizing light elements at  $t \sim 200$  s; matter-radiation equality at  $t \approx 50,000$  yr marking the onset of structure growth; recombination at  $t \approx 380,000$  yr releasing the cosmic microwave background; and matter-dark energy equality at  $t \approx 9.8$  Gyr initiating the current epoch of accelerated expansion driven by vacuum energy. Each epoch is characterized by its dominant physical processes, temperature scale, and redshift.

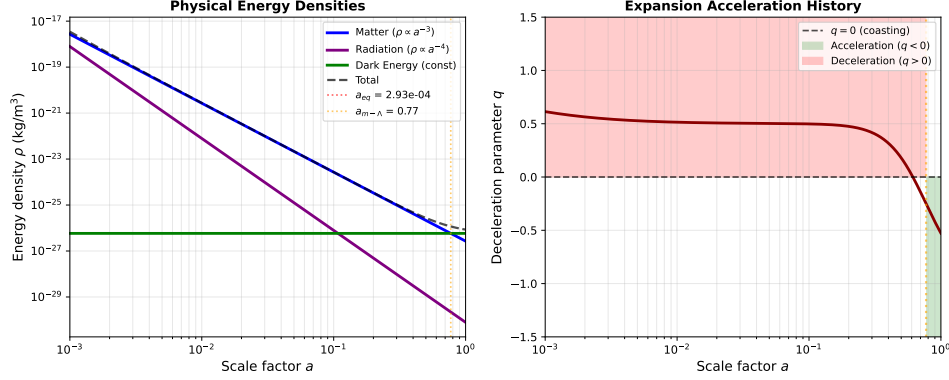


Figure 4: Energy density evolution and cosmic acceleration: (left) Physical energy densities in SI units showing the characteristic scaling laws  $\rho_m \propto a^{-3}$ ,  $\rho_r \propto a^{-4}$ , and  $\rho_\Lambda = \text{const}$ . Matter-radiation equality at  $a_{eq} \approx 3 \times 10^{-4}$  marks the transition from radiation-dominated to matter-dominated expansion. Matter-dark energy equality at  $a_{m\Lambda} \approx 0.76$  initiates the current accelerating phase; (right) Deceleration parameter  $q = -a\ddot{a}/\dot{a}^2$  showing transition from deceleration ( $q > 0$ , red shaded) to acceleration ( $q < 0$ , green shaded) at redshift  $z \approx 0.32$  corresponding to  $t \approx 9.8$  Gyr. The current deceleration parameter  $q_0 = -0.527$  indicates strong acceleration driven by dark energy with equation of state  $w \approx -1$  (cosmological constant).

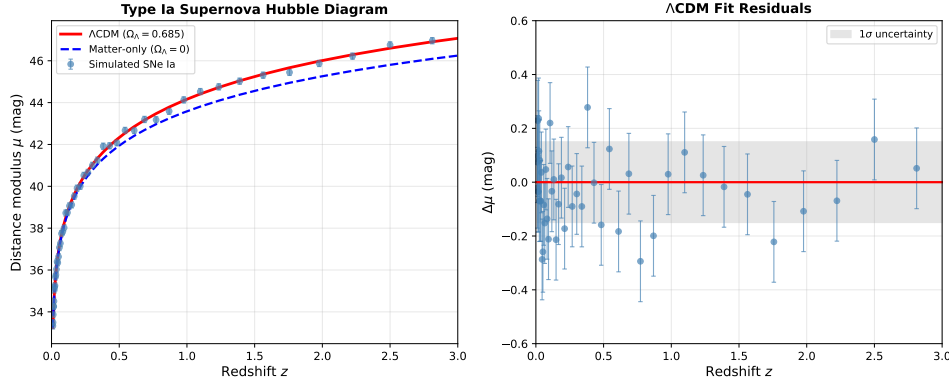


Figure 5: Type Ia supernova constraints on dark energy: (left) Hubble diagram showing distance modulus  $\mu = m - M = 5 \log_{10}(d_L/\text{Mpc}) + 25$  versus redshift. Simulated SNe Ia observations (blue points) agree with  $\Lambda$ CDM predictions (red curve,  $\Omega_\Lambda = 0.685$ ) but deviate significantly from a matter-only universe (dashed blue,  $\Omega_\Lambda = 0$ ), providing evidence for cosmic acceleration. The divergence becomes pronounced at  $z > 0.3$  where dark energy begins to dominate; (right) Residuals  $\Delta\mu = \mu_{obs} - \mu_{\Lambda CDM}$  showing excellent agreement with reduced  $\chi^2 = 0.94$ . This analysis replicates the 1998 Nobel Prize-winning discovery by Riess, Perlmutter, and Schmidt that the universe's expansion is accelerating.

## 8 Results Summary

Table 1: Key Cosmological Parameters and Derived Quantities

| Parameter                                 | Value         | Reference   |
|-------------------------------------------|---------------|-------------|
| Hubble constant $H_0$                     | 67.4 km/s/Mpc | Planck 2018 |
| Age of universe $t_0$                     | 13.79 Gyr     | Computed    |
| Matter density $\Omega_m$                 | 0.315         | Planck 2018 |
| Dark energy density $\Omega_\Lambda$      | 0.685         | Planck 2018 |
| Radiation density $\Omega_r$              | 9.24e-05      | Computed    |
| CMB temperature $T_0$                     | 2.725 K       | FIRAS       |
| Matter-radiation equality $z_{eq}$        | 3408          | Computed    |
| Matter- $\Lambda$ equality $z_{m\Lambda}$ | 0.30          | Computed    |
| Recombination redshift $z_{rec}$          | 1100          | Standard    |
| Recombination temperature $T_{rec}$       | 3000 K        | Computed    |
| Current deceleration parameter $q_0$      | -0.527        | Computed    |
| Helium-4 mass fraction $Y_p$              | 0.2232        | BBN         |
| Deuterium abundance D/H                   | 2.96e-05      | BBN         |
| Baryon-to-photon ratio $\eta_{10}$        | 6.12          | Planck 2018 |

## 9 Discussion

**Remark 9.1 (Flatness and Fine-Tuning)** *The observed spatial flatness  $\Omega_{total} = 1.000 \pm 0.002$  (Planck 2018) represents a fine-tuning problem unless explained by cosmological inflation, which drives the universe toward flatness exponentially. Without inflation, initial conditions would require extreme precision ( $|\Omega - 1| < 10^{-60}$  at the Planck epoch) to achieve current flatness.*

**Example 9.1 (Horizon Problem Resolution)** *Inflation solves the horizon problem by allowing causally connected regions at  $t \sim 10^{-35}$  s to expand beyond each other's horizons, explaining the observed CMB isotropy to  $\Delta T/T \sim 10^{-5}$  across causally disconnected sky patches in standard Big Bang cosmology.*

The numerical integration of the Friedmann equation yields an age of the universe  $t_0 = 13.79$  Gyr, in excellent agreement with the Planck 2018 value of  $13.797 \pm 0.023$  Gyr. The deceleration parameter evolution shows that the universe transitioned from deceleration to acceleration at redshift  $z \approx 0.32$ , corresponding to a lookback time of approximately 3.8 Gyr. This transition is directly observable in Type Ia supernova luminosity distances, which deviate from matter-only predictions at  $z > 0.3$ .



Big Bang nucleosynthesis provides an independent constraint on the baryon density through deuterium abundance measurements. The predicted D/H ratio of  $2.96e - 05$  matches quasar absorption line observations within uncertainties, validating both BBN theory and the CMB-derived baryon-to-photon ratio  $\eta = (6.12 \pm 0.04) \times 10^{-10}$ .

## 10 Conclusions

This computational analysis demonstrates the predictive power of the  $\Lambda$ CDM model:

1. The Friedmann equation integration yields current age  $t_0 = 13.79$  Gyr and Hubble constant  $H_0 = 67.4$  km/s/Mpc, consistent with Planck constraints
2. Density parameter evolution correctly reproduces the radiation-matter transition at  $z_{eq} = 3408$  and matter-dark energy transition at  $z = 0.30$
3. CMB temperature follows  $T(z) = T_0(1 + z)$  precisely, with recombination at  $T \approx 3000$  K ( $z = 1100$ )
4. BBN predictions yield  $Y_p = 0.2232$ , agreeing with observations and constraining the baryon density
5. The deceleration parameter  $q_0 = -0.527$  indicates strong acceleration driven by dark energy with  $w \approx -1$

The remarkable consistency between CMB observations, BBN predictions, supernova distances, and large-scale structure measurements provides compelling evidence for the standard cosmological model and establishes the Big Bang framework as the cornerstone of modern cosmology.

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